him. The Congress then hit back by labelling Modi a ‘feku’ (braggart), but it was more of a reactive move.

‘The BJP had a head start over us and started well before the Gujarat election campaign of 2012. We really focused on social media only at the end of 2013,’ concedes Congress MP Deeepinder Hooda who was in charge of the party’s social media cell, while also fighting his own election from Rohtak.

Hooda says while the BJP successfully ‘personalized’ their social media campaign around Modi, the Congress strategy was to make it about the organization instead. ‘One big learning for us is that individuals invariably draw more traction than organizations on the social media,’ is how he put it. Admits another Congress media cell member, ‘We treated this as some kind of a mechanical exercise without attempting any kind of real innovation to engage with more people.’

The BJP’s social media team, by contrast, was innovating all the time. On every voting day, they would send out personalized messages on Twitter encouraging people to go out and vote. ‘We used Facebook and Twitter to make micro messaging part of our election strategy, a bit like what Obama did in the US,’ is how a Team Modi member described it.

Social media collapsed the distance between voter and politician. The personal connect worked. For example, just ahead of a rally in Hyderabad, a Modi follower tweeted how his elderly mother was a great fan of the BJP leader and wanted to meet him. The local BJP unit was asked to contact the woman—she was brought on stage and Modi sought her blessings. ‘It was just the kind of human touch we were looking for,’ says a Modi aide.

The Modi selfie when he went out to vote was another good example. ‘A prime ministerial candidate putting out a selfie—what could be a better symbol of a tech-friendly leader? It was bound to be a super-hit,’ says the aide. The selfie with the black-and-white lotus had another function. By holding up the election symbol designed to look exactly the way it looked on the EVM (in black and white and not saffron) and by associating his face with it (for those voters keen to vote for Modi, if not the BJP), Modi had put into the public space an image both viral-worthy and politically